CHAPTER IX

The Sum of Small Signs

Kolkata & Odisha · November 2023

There comes a moment when the past begins to look unfamiliar, though nothing in it has changed. We return to the smallest things—a kindness, a conversation, a smile once carried home with unreasonable happiness—and wonder whether we had understood them at all. Yet memory offers no defence against the questions we bring to it. What was ordinary remains ordinary; what was precious remains precious. It is only the certainty with which we once held these things that quietly begins to disappear.

By the first week of November, Utkarsh had begun to suspect that his family considered staying at home for an entire year a minor form of negligence.

Every year, without fail, they went somewhere together. The destination changed, the arguments about luggage remained remarkably consistent, and someone invariably remembered an essential item only after it had become inconvenient to retrieve. This year, the destination was Odisha.

Utkarsh had looked forward to the journey. He liked the peculiar freedom of being away from familiar streets, of waking somewhere that had no immediate claim on his time. For a few days, there would be no coaching classes to hurry towards, no familiar benches, no unfinished mock tests waiting accusingly on his desk. He had left a bookmark at the next exercise. For once, he could pass a whole afternoon without calculating how many questions he ought to have finished.

Bhubaneswar greeted them with the warmth of a city in no particular hurry to acknowledge November. At Lingaraj Temple,

Utkarsh stood beneath the towering stone architecture and tried to imagine the generations of people who had come there before him, carrying prayers that must once have seemed as urgent as his own. Around him, his family moved between admiration and the practical concerns of travelling together. Someone wanted another photograph. Someone else wanted to know how much farther they had to walk. Utkarsh, who had been entrusted with remembering where they had left their footwear, discovered that historical grandeur did very little to improve his memory.

At Konark, the Sun Temple held his attention longer than he expected. He moved closer to one of the carved wheels, following the smaller figures worked into the stone. From a distance he had scarcely noticed them. Now each detail led him to another, and he was still examining the wheel when a family member called him over for a photograph.

He went, of course. There was no point travelling hundreds of kilometres to admire ancient craftsmanship if the family album couldn’t establish that he had stood in front of it.

Puri was different.

There, he could hear the sea before he reached it. Beyond the stalls and the voices on the beach, the waves kept breaking, one after another. In the evenings, families spread out along the shore; children ran towards the water and retreated shrieking when it reached them. Vendors called across the sand, and the lights behind him grew brighter as the horizon faded.

Utkarsh walked along the shore with his family, sometimes joining their conversations, sometimes falling a few steps behind. The wind kept finding its way through his hair, undoing whatever effort he had made to arrange it. He eventually gave up. The Bay of Bengal, he decided, was not a place where personal dignity could be maintained through hairstyle alone.

Along the beach, small stalls stood beneath temporary lights, displaying shells, ornaments, toys, and handmade objects. He stopped at one selling little boxes fashioned from dried bamboo, their pieces joined with thread. They were simple things, imperfect

in the way objects made by hand sometimes were, and he found himself examining them more carefully than their price seemed to require.

One was just large enough, he thought, to hold a bottle of perfume.

He turned it over in his hands, checked the fastening, and bought it.

He had not mentioned Sanondita to anyone.

The thought of her birthday had accompanied him from Kolkata, quietly enough that he could almost pretend it wasn't there. November thirteenth was approaching. He knew the date because he had once noticed it on Facebook, and remembering it had required no effort at all. What to do with that knowledge was proving considerably more difficult.

He put the little box away and returned to his family.

For the rest of the evening, he stayed with his family. He laughed at something someone said and joined the argument over where they should eat. When he shifted the little box out of the way, his fingers found its fastening through the bag. He left it alone. There would be time to look at it again when nobody was waiting for him.

The visit to Jagannath Temple began with a queue that seemed to have existed long before Utkarsh was born and showed every intention of surviving him.

He had been warned about the crowds. Even so, he kept expecting the queue to open out beyond the next turn. Each time they moved, another stretch of waiting appeared ahead.

His family stayed together as best they could, occasionally losing sight of one another behind shoulders and raised hands, only to reunite a few steps later. Somewhere ahead, bells rang above the murmur of prayers. The air was warm with incense and the closeness of hundreds of people, and every so often a chant rose through the crowd, gathering voices as it travelled.

Utkarsh had never been particularly good at waiting without looking at the time. Unfortunately, his phone was not with him, and

the temple offered no convenient means of measuring how much patience he had left.

He tried counting the pillars he could see. He lost count when the crowd moved. He tried remembering a mathematical formula he had revised before the journey and discovered, to his considerable embarrassment, that even the formula had apparently gone on holiday.

Yet beneath his mild complaints, he was glad to be there.

There was something difficult to describe about standing among so many strangers who had travelled from different places, carrying different troubles and hopes, and watching them turn towards the same sanctum. An elderly man ahead of him kept his palms joined even while being jostled. A child somewhere behind them asked a question that nobody seemed able to hear. His family exchanged brief glances whenever the crowd pressed too tightly, reassuring one another without saying much.

For a while, Utkarsh stopped thinking about how long the queue might take.

Then, quite suddenly, they were moving faster.

The doorway came nearer. Voices rose. Someone urged the people ahead to keep walking.

After all that waiting, Utkarsh had imagined he would have at least a moment to himself. Apparently, the gods operated on a rather stricter schedule.

The crowd pressed forward. He caught sight of Lord Jagannath, and for a few seconds, everything he had intended to ask for deserted him.

Except one thought.

An unreasonable little possibility that had followed him all the way from Kolkata.

Before he could quite finish it, the crowd had carried him onward.

And just like that, his audience was over.

Outside, he found himself blinking in the daylight, trying to understand how something he had waited so long to experience could have passed so quickly.

One of his family members asked whether he had managed to see the deity.

“Yes,” Utkarsh said.

“Properly?”

He considered the question.

“Well, I saw him. Whether he managed to see me is another matter.”

Someone laughed and told him not to talk nonsense.

Utkarsh smiled, but he did not feel cheated by the brevity of the darshan. He had seen enough to remember the moment clearly: the sudden opening in the crowd, the glimpse of the deity, the strange urgency with which one thought had arrived when all the others had disappeared.

He could have wished for his examination results. That would have been sensible. His family had invested so much hope in his future, and he had spent enough evenings worrying about whether he was doing justice to their faith in him. There were vacancies to be counted, cutoffs to be estimated, and entire portions of the syllabus that seemed determined to remain unfamiliar no matter how often he revised them.

He knew all that.

Still, when the moment came, his mind had gone somewhere else.

He glanced at his family as they made their way out. They would have understood a prayer for his future. He could almost have told them that was what he had asked for, and nobody would have questioned it. He was relieved that nobody asked.

By the time his family began discussing where they should go next, he had joined the conversation again. There were practical questions to settle, food to find, and the usual disagreement about whether everyone was tired enough to return to their rooms.

The temple gradually disappeared behind them.

Utkarsh did not look back immediately. He was listening to an argument about lunch, offering an opinion nobody had requested, and trying to remember whether he had packed the little bamboo box securely among his belongings.

Only later, when the day had settled into its ordinary succession of meals, conversations, and photographs, did he remember those few seconds again.

He tried to remember whether he had finished the wish before the crowd moved him on. All he could recover was that sudden glimpse, and how quickly he had thought of her. He had been away for days. She had still been the first person to come to mind.

By the time they returned to Kolkata, the journey had begun to acquire the peculiar unreality of a holiday already finished. The photographs remained on their phones, the clothes had returned to their familiar places, and the sea, which had seemed so determined to accompany them everywhere, had finally been persuaded to stay in Odisha.

Utkarsh unpacked with considerably less enthusiasm than he had packed. A few things went into the cupboard, others onto his desk, and one shirt remained draped over a chair for reasons that became less defensible with each passing day.

Among his belongings was the little bamboo box.

He took it out carefully, brushing a stray grain of sand from its edge. The thread holding its pieces together had been pulled tight by hand, leaving small irregularities where the bamboo met. It was neither expensive nor particularly remarkable. He had seen dozens like it along the beach. Yet he had spent an unreasonable amount of time choosing this one.

He set it beside the perfume.

The bottle fitted, though not quite as comfortably as he had imagined. He adjusted it, tried another position, and lowered the lid again. This time it closed. He ran his thumb along the join to check,

then opened it once more; he wanted her to be able to take the bottle out easily.

That, at least, was one problem solved.

The other was November thirteenth.

It fell on a Monday.

Utkarsh knew Sanondita might not attend coaching. Her appearances had become less predictable in recent weeks, and he had learned that expecting to see her was an excellent way to spend an afternoon discovering that he wouldn't. Still, Mondays belonged to their ordinary routine, and ordinary routines had a way of making possibilities seem more dependable than they were.

He had not asked whether she would come.

Asking would have been simple enough. A message, a casual question during class, perhaps something about whether she had any plans for the following week. They were comfortable enough with each other for such conversations.

But he knew himself.

A harmless question might lead to another. He would begin wondering why she had answered in a particular way, whether she had hesitated, whether the conversation had ended too quickly. He had already developed an impressive ability to turn a sentence of five words into an evening's occupation. There seemed little reason to encourage it.

Instead, he considered a birthday treat.

Nothing elaborate. Somewhere near the coaching centre, perhaps, after class. Something to eat, a little conversation, the usual teasing. He imagined her objecting to his choice of restaurant, or insisting that she wasn't particularly hungry before examining the menu with suspicious thoroughness. He could almost hear himself accusing her of having come solely to criticise his arrangements.

The imagined conversation made him smile.

Then he caught himself.

He had begun assigning dialogue to someone who hadn’t even agreed to appear in the scene.

He returned to his books.

For a while, he managed to concentrate. A mathematics problem occupied him long enough to forget the date, and the satisfaction of reaching the correct answer reminded him why he had once found studying so absorbing. He checked the final step before moving on. For those few minutes he had wanted only to reach the answer, and the small satisfaction of doing so remained with him. He began the next question while he still had his concentration.

He turned the page.

His phone lay beside the notebook.

He resisted the temptation to pick it up, partly because there was nothing he needed to check and partly because he had already checked it twice.

By the evening of November twelfth, the gift was ready.

He had placed the perfume inside the bamboo box and folded a small piece of paper to go with it. Writing the note had taken longer than he cared to admit. The difficulty was not finding something complimentary to say. It was deciding how much of what he felt could be allowed to resemble an ordinary birthday message.

He wrote one sentence.

Your presence alone would make the angels question their own perfection.

He read it once, then again.

It was extravagant. He knew that. He lowered the paper, then brought it closer and read it again. Alone at his desk, he could bear the sentence. Imagining her holding it was harder. His thumb rested beside the words, careful not to smudge them.

He folded the paper and placed it inside.

For a moment, he considered removing it. The perfume was enough. People gave birthday presents to friends all the time; there was no need to make the gesture more complicated than it already was.

But the note remained where he had put it.

He closed the box.

Outside his window, the evening continued without consulting him. A motorcycle passed along the road. Someone called to a neighbour from a balcony. Somewhere nearby, a television played loudly enough for several households to enjoy a programme none of them had chosen.

Utkarsh cleared a space on his desk and opened his notebook again.

He would wish her at midnight, or perhaps in the morning. He hadn't decided. If she came to coaching, he could give her the present afterward. If there was time, he might suggest going somewhere nearby. If she had other plans, that would be perfectly understandable.

He had decided where they might sit, although he still hadn't decided when to send a birthday wish. That made him smile. He wrote down the next problem and bent over his notebook.

The gift stood at the far end of the desk.

He had placed it there so that it wouldn't distract him.

From where he sat, he could see it perfectly.

November thirteenth arrived without any particular regard for the arrangements Utkarsh had made in his head.

He had wished Sanondita a happy birthday on WhatsApp. It was a simple message, the sort one could send without inviting questions or appearing to have spent an unreasonable amount of time thinking about it. He had considered adding something else, then decided against it. The gift already contained more words than he would have trusted himself to say aloud.

By the time he left for coaching, the little bamboo box was still at home.

He had thought about carrying it. Then he had imagined reaching the classroom with it in his bag, waiting through an entire lesson, and discovering that she hadn't come. He could give it to her another day. There was no urgency. A birthday present did not

become worthless at midnight, whatever the greeting-card industry might prefer people to believe.

Still, he hoped she would be there.

He reached the coaching centre and climbed the familiar stairs. Voices drifted through the corridor. Someone was laughing about an answer in a previous examination; someone else was explaining, with great confidence, a shortcut that Utkarsh suspected would take considerably longer than the original method.

He entered the classroom.

Sanondita's place was empty.

He noticed it before he noticed anything else.

There was no reason to be surprised. He had anticipated precisely this possibility. He put his bag down, took out his notebook, and joined a conversation about the upcoming examinations. When someone made a ridiculous claim about the expected cutoff, Utkarsh supplied an even more ridiculous figure, and the others laughed.

For a few minutes, he forgot to look towards the door.

Then someone entered, and he looked up.

It wasn't her.

The class began.

Utkarsh followed the lesson, answered a question when the teacher asked, and wrote down the important points. There were stretches in which his attention remained exactly where it belonged. There were others when he became conscious of the empty place nearby and had to find his way back to the page.

He had known she might not come.

It was remarkable how little comfort there was in having been right.

After class, he walked out with the others. The afternoon was ordinary enough to be almost irritating. Traffic moved along the road, vendors called to passing customers, and people hurried towards destinations that had nothing to do with his disappointment.

He considered buying something to eat, then went home instead.

The birthday treat had been his idea. Sanondita had never heard of it. She had not declined an invitation, broken an arrangement, or even arrived late.

There was nothing to be upset about.

He understood this so thoroughly that he found himself repeating it.

Later, he opened Instagram.

He was not looking for anything in particular. At least, that was what he told himself as he moved through the familiar succession of photographs, reels, and stories. A few posts made him smile. One contained a joke he considered sending to Sanondita before remembering that she might be occupied with her birthday.

Then he saw her photographs.

He recognised her immediately.

She was at a small private theatre-cum-restaurant, the kind of place arranged for people who wanted to spend time together away from the noise of an ordinary dining room. The photographs showed enough of the setting for him to understand where she had been, but not enough to answer the question that came to him almost at once.

Who had taken her there?

He looked again.

There was no reason to do so. The photographs had not changed.

For a moment, his mind supplied a name with such readiness that it frightened him a little.

Nayan.

He had no proof. He knew that. He had seen a name on Facebook, heard Sanondita speak of him, and spent far too much time arranging small pieces of information into a picture that might not resemble the truth at all.

Perhaps it was Nayan.

Perhaps it wasn’t.

Perhaps she had gone with friends. Perhaps there were people outside the photographs. Perhaps the place was less private than it appeared. Perhaps the entire business was perfectly ordinary, and Utkarsh, who had managed to complicate a birthday that did not belong to him, was now trying to complicate its photographs as well.

He put the phone down.

A moment later, he picked it up again.

He had not imagined that she would spend the day alone. He had known there would be people in her life who mattered to her, people whose names he might never hear. He had known she could have plans of her own.

He had known all of it.

Yesterday evening, he had still been deciding where to take her after coaching.

He sat very still.

The thought was so embarrassing that, for an instant, he almost laughed.

What an idiot.

He looked away from the screen. The box stood where he had left it, its lid closed over the note. Yesterday, he had kept glancing at it with pleasure. Now he could scarcely bear to look at it long enough to move it.

The little box on his desk. The perfume. The restaurant he had imagined. The conversations he had rehearsed without knowing whether she would even come.

He had prepared an entire afternoon around a possibility.

And the worst part was that this was hardly the first time.

His mind went back, without permission, to the classroom months earlier. To the small adjustments he had made so that she might sit beside him. To the ridiculous happiness of finding her already there. To the way he had once carried an ordinary conversation home and remembered it long after he had forgotten what the teacher had taught that day.

The umbrella came next.

He remembered the rain, the narrow shelter beneath it, the care he had taken to keep her dry. He remembered how reluctant he had been to let the walk end.

He had never forgotten any of it.

Now he wondered what, exactly, he had been remembering.

Perhaps she remembered a walk with a friend. Perhaps the things he had kept returning to—the rain, her laughter, the place beside him—had never needed explaining to her. He could remember how close she had stood beneath the umbrella. He could not remember anything she had said that made it a promise.

Had he ever needed those things to mean anything else?

He wanted to say no.

He could not quite manage it.

And then another thought arrived, quieter and more difficult to dismiss.

What if he was wrong about the photographs?

He remembered what Sanondita had said when he had asked about Nayan. Just because a girl went somewhere with a boy did not mean he was her boyfriend.

He had understood the words when she spoke them. He understood them now.

What if she had meant exactly what she said?

What if something had changed since then?

What if nothing had changed at all?

The questions contradicted one another. He could see that perfectly well. But whenever he settled on one explanation, another seemed to rise from some neglected corner of his memory.

He thought of asking her.

Not accusing her. Not demanding anything. Just asking, casually, how she had spent her birthday.

They were friends. Such a question would hardly be unusual.

He even imagined how the conversation might begin.

Then he imagined her answering.

He turned the phone face down.

There were answers he wanted badly enough to search for in every photograph, every passing remark, every small alteration in her behaviour.

And there were answers he could not bring himself to hear.

His hand stayed beside the phone. He could turn it over and ask about her birthday in a few words. He waited until the urge passed, then moved his hand away.

Across the room, his books remained open where he had left them.

He sat down and tried to read.

The first paragraph made sense. So did the second. By the third, he realised he had been looking at the same line for several minutes.

He closed his eyes briefly, then began again.

Outside, evening had settled over the neighbourhood. Somewhere a child was being called home. A motorcycle passed beneath his window, its sound rising and fading along the road.

Utkarsh kept his eyes on the page.

He reached the end of the page and could not remember where he had begun. When he turned back, he kept one finger beneath the line. This time, he would read it through.

November fourteenth passed without offering Utkarsh any particular revelation.

He attended to the things that required his attention, spoke when spoken to, and tried to recover the rhythm of his preparation. He began with the questions he had left unfinished. By midday, there were answers on a page that had been nearly blank the night before. He counted them and went on.

He found that he could still study. This ought to have been reassuring. Instead, it irritated him to discover how easily the mind could return to its proper work for twenty minutes and then abandon it without so much as an apology.

He did not open the photographs again.

He remembered them well enough.

The gift remained on his desk, where he had left it before the thirteenth. Once, while reaching for a book, he moved it aside. Later, when he needed the space again, he put it back.

He considered what he would do when he next saw Sanondita.

Giving her the present had seemed perfectly natural when he bought it. Now he could imagine himself producing it from his bag and feeling absurdly conscious of his own hands. He might say something foolish. Worse, he might try so hard not to say anything foolish that the effort would become obvious.

He briefly considered not giving it to her at all.

Then he looked at the little bamboo box.

He had chosen it before he knew how her birthday would go. Standing at the stall, he had turned it over to check that the thread held, imagining her opening it. He still wanted her to have it.

His hand lingered on the lid. If he took the note out, he could give her the perfume more easily. But he had meant the words when he wrote them. He meant them now, even with the photographs still in his mind.

He put it carefully into his bag, where his books would not press against it. Tomorrow, if she came, he would have to decide when to hand it over. For tonight, he closed the bag.

On November fifteenth, Sanondita came to coaching.

Utkarsh saw her when he entered the classroom. For a moment, he was aware of her presence with an intensity that made the rest of the room seem oddly distant. Then she looked towards him, and the moment passed into the familiar business of greeting one another.

There she was, entirely herself.

He had spent two days questioning the meaning of things she had said months ago. She was occupied with the beginning of another class.

He took his seat.

Their conversation was ordinary. There was something about the lesson, a remark about the teacher, a small exchange that might have belonged to any afternoon since they had become friends.

Utkarsh answered her as he always did. At one point, something amused them both, and he laughed before remembering that he had been miserable only the previous evening.

The discovery annoyed him.

Apparently, his feelings had not even the decency to remain consistent.

He was glad she had come. That was the simple, inconvenient truth of it. He had wanted to see her, and now he could. Whatever he suspected, whatever he feared, the familiar ease between them had not disappeared.

It would have been easier, perhaps, if something had changed.

If she had been distant, he might have blamed the awkwardness on that. If she had seemed unusually attentive, he might have found another reason to hope. Instead, she behaved as she always had, leaving him with nothing to interpret except his own relief.

The class continued.

Utkarsh followed the lesson more closely than he had expected. He wrote down the important points, checked an answer, and joined a brief discussion when the teacher asked the students to explain their reasoning. Beside him, Sanondita turned a page in her notebook.

He noticed the movement and returned to his work.

For a second he watched her hand settle on the fresh page. Then he found his place in his own notebook. He had missed a few words, but the next sentence helped him recover them. He wrote them down and kept listening.

But the afternoon did not belong entirely to his uneasiness.

They talked. They laughed. For a little while, he forgot the photographs and the questions they had left behind. He was simply sitting beside someone whose company he enjoyed.

That, too, was real.

He did not ask about the birthday photographs. Once, he nearly did; then the lesson moved on, and he let the opening pass. He turned back to the teacher, leaving the question unasked.

When the class ended, chairs scraped against the floor and the room filled with the familiar disorder of people gathering their belongings. Sanondita closed her notebook. Utkarsh put away his pen, checked that he had everything, and felt the small weight of the bamboo box inside his bag.

He had almost forgotten it during the lesson.

Now he could think of little else.

They left the classroom together.

The aisle outside was busy with students moving towards the stairs, some still discussing the lesson, others already absorbed in their phones. Utkarsh walked beside Sanondita, listening as she spoke. He answered at the appropriate moments, though part of his attention had gone to the bag hanging from his shoulder.

He could give it to her here.

No. Too many people.

On the stairs, perhaps.

That would be worse. Someone would inevitably come up behind them, and he would find himself presenting a birthday gift while attempting not to obstruct an entire building.

Outside, then.

He had made the decision three times before they reached the ground floor.

Sanondita said something that made him smile. He replied with a joke, and she laughed.

For an instant, the sound returned him to all the afternoons he had spent hoping for precisely this: another conversation, another few minutes before they went their separate ways.

He felt the familiar happiness rise, followed almost immediately by the memory of how foolish he had felt two days earlier.

He let neither show.

They stepped out of the building.

The afternoon light had begun to soften. Vehicles passed along the road, and the pavement was crowded with people who had places to be. Sanondita moved a little ahead of him.

Utkarsh stopped.

He could still leave the gift in his bag. He could take it home, put it away, and spare himself the awkwardness he had spent the entire afternoon anticipating.

But she had already begun to walk away.

“Sanondita, wait.”

She turned.

“There’s something for you.”

“For me? What?”

He opened his bag.

For one ridiculous second, his fingers caught against the fastening, and he wondered whether the box had somehow grown larger since morning. Then he found it and drew it out.

The box rested in his palm, smaller than it had seemed on his desk. He checked the fastening with his thumb. Inside, the folded note lay beside the perfume; he could still picture the words beneath the crease. He had carried them through the whole lesson. In a moment, he would no longer be able to take them back.

He held it towards her.

“A little late,” he said. “Happy birthday.”

Sanondita looked at the box, then at him.

“For me?”

He smiled. “Unless there’s another Sanondita I should be giving it to.”

She seemed genuinely surprised. For a moment she simply looked at what he was holding, and Utkarsh became conscious of how carefully he had imagined this exchange without ever knowing what she might say.

Then she took it.

“Thank you, Utkarsh.”

There was nothing elaborate about the words. She said them warmly, with the surprise still present in her face.

He wanted to tell her that it was nothing.

The words were ready, an easy way to get past his embarrassment. Then he looked at the box in her hands. He had chosen it carefully. He wanted her to have it. He let her thank him.

So he only smiled.

She held the little box in her hands. He could see the thread along its edges, the uneven fastening, the place where the bamboo had been fitted together by someone whose name he would never know.

For a moment, he remembered the beach at Puri: the stalls beneath their temporary lights, the noise of the sea, and himself standing there, turning the box over while imagining this very afternoon.

He had not imagined the two days in between.

Sanondita thanked him once more, and they began to say goodbye.

The note remained folded inside the box.

She had not read it yet.

Utkarsh watched her take the gift with her, carrying words he had chosen when the world had seemed a little easier to understand.

At home, Utkarsh put his bag beside the desk and took out his books. The space where he had kept the gift was bare. He set his notebook there, then drew it towards him.

He wondered whether she had opened the box.

On the beach, and later at his desk, he had imagined her lifting the lid. He had never been able to imagine what followed with quite the same ease. Now she could be unfolding the paper, and he would have no chance to explain why he had written it that way.

He went to wash his hands. When he returned, he checked his phone before sitting down. There was nothing from her.

She would open it when she had time. Perhaps she already had. He tried to picture the box among her own things, somewhere he had never been. Until that afternoon, he had always known where it was.

He picked up his pen.

A few minutes passed.

His phone lit up.

Sanondita had sent him a message.

She had opened the gift and was thanking him again.

Utkarsh read it once, then a second time, not because the words were difficult but because he had been waiting to see them without quite admitting that he was waiting.

He smiled.

His shoulders eased. He read the message once more, looking for a reference to the folded paper. There wasn't one. He held his thumb above the keyboard, tempted to ask whether she had found it. Then he moved back to the beginning of her message. She was thanking him. He could answer that.

He typed a reply, deleted it, and wrote another.

Then he sent something simple.

They exchanged a few messages. He kept the conversation open after the last one, then read back what he had sent. He had not asked about the note. She had not mentioned it. There was room to write something else, and for a while he left his thumb resting there.

It was a small exchange between friends.

He was glad of it.

And somewhere beneath that gladness was the familiar ache of wanting a moment to become more than it had promised to be.

He set the phone aside and returned to his notebook.

The problem he had abandoned was still waiting for him. He read it from the beginning, worked through the calculation, and arrived at an answer that did not match any of the options.

He checked his arithmetic.

One careless sign had spoiled the entire solution.

Utkarsh stared at it for a moment, then laughed softly.

At least this mistake could be found.

He corrected the line and began again.